

The First-Time Home Buyer's Handbook - Printable Worksheets

From *The First-Time Home Buyer's Handbook* by Thomas Ashcroft (Oro Enigma Publishing). Print as many copies as you need. Chapter references are to the book.

Worksheet 1 - Am I Ready? The Readiness Checklist

	Yes / No / By when
I expect to stay in the area at least five years	
My job (or ours) has been stable for two years in the same field	
I have pulled all three credit reports and disputed the errors	
My middle credit score is 620 or more (580 for FHA)	
I have made every payment on time for the last 12 months	
My card balances are under 30 per cent of their limits	
I have the down payment (3 to 5 per cent, or 3.5 for FHA) saved or gifted with a letter	
I have the closing costs (2 to 5 per cent) on top of the down payment	
I will still have three months of housing cost in reserve after closing	
I know my two ratios (Worksheet 3) and the comfortable payment	
I have read Chapter 5 and know which loan	

type fits	
I have written the needs, wants and will-nots (Worksheet 5)	
I have applied to the state or city first-time buyer programme, if eligible	
VA: I have my Certificate of Eligibility	
The money has been in my account two months, or every deposit is documented	

If every line is yes, get pre-approved (Chapter 7). If not, the "by when" column is your plan.

Worksheet 2 - The Six-Month Credit Plan

Bureau	Score today (mortgage FICO)	Errors found	Disputed on	Resolved on	Score at 3 months	Score at 6 months
Equifax						
Experian						
TransUnion						

Card or loan	Limit	Balance today	Utilisation	Target balance (under 10 per cent)	Pay before statement date on	Done

Rule	From (date)	Kept?
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Every bill on time, every month (set up autopay for the minimum)		
No new credit of any kind		
No account closed		
Small collections paid, with "pay for delete" requested in writing		
Authorised-user request made (whose card)		
Reports re-checked at 3 months		
Reports re-checked at 6 months		

Worksheet 3 - The Budget: How Much House

	Monthly
Gross household income (before tax)	
Take-home pay (after tax and deductions)	
Car loans and leases	
Student loans (the payment the lender will count)	
Card minimums	
Child support, alimony, other debts	
Total other debts (A)	
28 per cent of gross income (comfortable housing cost)	
36 per cent of gross income minus A (comfortable housing cost by the back-end ratio)	
My comfortable housing cost: the lower of the two (B)	

The house I am pricing	Price	Down payment	Loan
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Line	At rate: ____	At rate: ____	At rate: ____
Principal and interest (Chapter 4 table)			
Mortgage insurance (PMI or MIP)			
Property tax (county rate x price, divided by 12)			
Homeowner's insurance (quote, divided by 12)			
HOA dues			
Total housing cost			
Is it under B?			
Take-home minus total housing cost minus A			
Is what is left at least a third of take-home? (the house-poor test)			

Worksheet 4 - The Lender

Comparison (three Loan Estimates, then the Closing Disclosure)

Same day, same loan type, same price and down payment.

Loan Estimate line	Lender 1	Lender 2	Lender 3	Closing Disclosure (final)
Lender and loan officer				
Loan type and term				
Loan amount				
Interest rate				
Locked? Until when				
Principal and interest				
Estimated escrow (tax and insurance)				
Mortgage insurance				
Total monthly payment				
APR (page 3)				

A. Origination charges (points, fees)				
B. Services you cannot shop for				
C. Services you can shop for				
D. Total loan costs (A + B + C)				
E. Taxes and government fees				
F. Prepays				
G. Initial escrow deposit				
Lender credits				
Seller credits				
Total closing costs				
Cash to close				
In 5 years: total paid (page 3)				
Prepayment penalty? Balloon? (both must				

be no)				
Best offer taken back to the others on				

Closing Disclosure check: rate and points match the lock; A has not risen; C has risen by no more than 10 per cent in total; cash to close within a few hundred dollars. Every difference asked about on: _____

Worksheet 5 - The House-Hunting Checklist

Needs (without these, no)	Wants (these decide between two)	Will-nots (these rule it out)

Price band: from _____ to _____ (5 per cent above the comfortable price, no higher)

The viewing card (one per house; photograph the labels)

Address:	Asking:	Days on market:	Price history:

Check	Notes	OK / Ask / Red flag
Roof from the street (age, sag, moss, missing shingles)		
Gutters, downspouts, where the water goes; grading		

Foundation and brick: cracks (horizontal or stair-step?)		
Basement or crawl space: stains, smell, efflorescence, sump		
Electrical panel: brand, amps, spare breakers		
Furnace and water heater: dates on the labels		
Air conditioning: date on the condenser		
Windows: open one per room; fogging; rot		
Every tap and flush; under every sink; water pressure		
Every ceiling: stains		
Attic: insulation, daylight, animals		
Pipes: galvanised? polybutylene (grey plastic)?		
Year built (lead paint before 1978; asbestos before 1980)		
Flood map checked; insurance quote possible		
Permits match the rooms and square footage		
HOA: dues, reserves, minutes, litigation, special assessments		

Neighbourhood at 8 a.m., 6 p.m. and 11 p.m. Saturday		
Comparable sales in the last 6 months		
Do I like it, after all of the above?		

Worksheet 6 - The Offer Worksheet

Address	
Asking price	
Comparable 1: address, sold price, date, difference from this house	
Comparable 2	
Comparable 3	
What the comparables say the house is worth	
Repairs to price in (from the viewing and Chapter 10), with estimates	
Market: days on market for this house; typical for the area; offers expected	
Opening offer	
The most I will pay for this house (set before the negotiation; do not cross)	
Earnest money (1 to 3 per cent)	
Down payment and loan type	
Financing contingency: yes, by (date)	

Appraisal contingency: yes; gap clause? cap:	
Inspection contingency: days; full / shortened / informational	
Closing date; rent-back?	
Seller concessions asked (closing costs, up to the loan's cap)	
Buyer-agent compensation asked of the seller	
Included: appliances, window coverings, other	
Escalation clause? increment and cap (equals the most I will pay)	
Attorney review period (if the state has one)	
Sent on; response due; outcome	

Worksheet 7 - The Inspection List

Inspection	Ordered?	Date	Cost	Result
General home inspection (I will attend)				
Sewer scope (over 40 years old or big trees)				
Radon test				
Termite / wood-destroying insect				
Chimney				
Septic and well water				
Mould				
Structural engineer (if the foundation is questioned)				
Insurance quotes obtained (three)				
HOA documents read (budget, reserves,				

minutes, litigation)				
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Sorting the report

Item from the report	Category (1 safety and structure / 2 costly but expected / 3 cosmetic)	Contractor quote	Ask for: repair / credit / price cut	Outcome

Contingency deadline: _____ Decision (proceed /
renegotiate / walk) made on: _____

Worksheet 8 - Contract to Keys: The Do-Not List and the Closing-Day Checklist

The do-not list, from contract to recorded deed (put it on the refrigerator)

	Kept
No new credit: no cards, car, furniture plan, buy-now-pay-later, store card	
No account closed or debt paid off without asking the lender first	
No job change, self-employment, unpaid leave or reduced hours without asking first	
No large or undocumented deposits; no moving money between accounts unannounced	
No co-signing	
No missed or late payment	
Closing and reserve money not touched	
No credit pulls by anyone	
Furniture waits for the keys	

Conditions and dates

	Date / done
Earnest money delivered	
Rate locked until	
Inspection contingency ends	
Appraisal ordered; received; value	
Insurance binder sent to the lender	
Conditional approval received; conditions cleared	
Clear to close	
Closing Disclosure received (at least 3 business days before closing) and compared on Worksheet 4	
Wiring instructions received from the closing agent by phone; confirmed on a number I looked up myself	
Wire sent (a day early); receipt confirmed by phone	
Final walkthrough (within 24 hours): repairs done with receipts; inclusions present; everything works; no new damage	

Closing day

	Done
Photo ID (two forms if asked)	
Cashier's cheque, if not wiring	
Closing Disclosure and the Loan Estimate for comparison	
Proof of insurance	
Chequebook for small adjustments	
Signed: note, mortgage or deed of trust, Closing Disclosure, affidavits	
Deed recorded; keys, codes, openers and manuals received	
Closing package filed (deed, note, CD, title policy, inspection, warranties, disclosure)	

Worksheet 9 - The First-Year Maintenance Calendar

Month	Task	Done
Week 1	Locks and garage code changed; shut-offs found and labelled; alarms tested; utilities moved; homestead exemption filed; house photographed for insurance	
Every month	Furnace / AC filter; sump pump test; alarms; walk round after storms	
January	Check the attic for ice dams and condensation; check the tax assessment notice	
February	Review the insurance (rebuild cost, deductible, flood); dryer vent cleaned	
March	Homestead or exemption deadline in many counties; appeal the assessment if above the purchase price	
April	Gutters cleaned; roof checked from the ground; grading and downspouts; caulk around windows and doors	

May	Air conditioning serviced; outdoor taps turned on; deck and fence checked; termite check at the foundation	
June	Water heater flushed; anode rod checked (every 3 to 5 years); sewer line scoped if old (every 5)	
July	Exterior paint and trim checked; driveway sealed if asphalt	
August	PMI check: balance against 80 per cent of original value; servicer's rules for early cancellation	
September	Furnace serviced; chimney inspected and swept; smoke and CO alarm batteries	
October	Gutters cleaned; outdoor taps drained and shut off before frost; hoses stored	
November	Attic insulation and animals checked; weather-stripping; escrow analysis read	
December	Closing folder and Form 1098 ready for tax time; maintenance account topped up; next year's list from the inspection report	
Every 3 years	Septic pumped	

First-year repair list (from the inspection, in order: water, safety, systems, the rest)		
1.		
2.		
3.		
4.		
5.		